ARTICLE 2 CORINTHIANS 4:1-7 8 NOV 2026 NORM REED

Jars of Clay

We treat the glory of God like the Crown Jewels. Thick glass, a darkened vault, a moving walkway, a respectful distance. Its value, we tell ourselves, is wrapped up in its remoteness — untouched, static, pristine, and completely removed from ordinary life.

Paul will not have it.

In 2 Corinthians 4:6 he writes of the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ. The glory is in a face — *prosōpon*. And Paul has just spent a whole chapter on a face. Moses came down from the mountain with his skin shining, and he put a veil over it. Israel could not look at the glory, so the glory was covered up.

Then Paul says that in Christ the veil is gone. The face is uncovered. Whatever else that means, it means God's glory is not kept behind glass for our protection. It is a face you are meant to look at.

This is where I found myself reading Hans Urs von Balthasar (1905–1988), and not getting out again quickly. Balthasar's complaint, across the long work he called a theological aesthetics, is that the church quietly dropped beauty from the list of things that tell us about God — kept the true and the good, let the beautiful go to the art galleries. His answer is that God's glory is not an idea to be deduced but a form to be seen; and that the form is a person. You do not work your way back to the glory from a set of propositions about it. You look at it.[1]

Paul got there first, in a single clause. The glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.

Not the Crown Jewels, then. More like a blacksmith stepping into a cold room with a bar of white-hot iron straight from the forge. You do not appreciate it from a safe distance. You know it is in the room because the heat reaches your face.

The Unlikeliest of Luggage

Then verse seven.

> *But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us.*

If the glory is in the face of Christ, the carrying of it is left to terracotta. Cheap, fragile, easily broken pots — *ostrakina skeuē*, the throwaway crockery of the ancient world, the kind you did not mend.

And Paul tells us why, in the same breath. So that the surpassing power may belong to God and not to us.

That is not a consolation offered to fragile people. It is the reason for the arrangement. The pot is cheap *so that* nobody mistakes where the power is coming from. Put the same treasure in gold and the question becomes an open one.

Painting the Pot Gold

In the work I do with the justice system, the temptation is always to paint the clay pot gold. We want quick fixes. We want polished religious responses and measurable programmes. We want the triumphant power of God to break in and fix things, and when it doesn't, we set about facilitating the fix ourselves. We want the glory to go to our strategy, our funding, our intervention. We become the saviours.

But a programme has a syllabus and a graduation date. Presence requires your soul.

When we step away from the religious machinery and simply walk alongside people at a human pace, offering a presence committed to the long haul, we step out of the way. That is the arrangement working as designed.

What Paul Calls It

Paul had a name for the gold paint, and he used it a few verses earlier. We have renounced underhanded ways. We refuse to tamper with God's word. We do not proclaim ourselves.

Tampering is not lying. It is improving. It is the small adjustment that makes the message land better, the clay pot buffed up because the room expects something finer. And verse five names what sits underneath it: we proclaim not ourselves.

The Tap on the Pot

Which brings me to the tightness in the chest.

The biggest tell is how I handle pushback from respected people. My default is to justify, to argue the strategy. When I find myself doing that, I realise it has become *my* strategy. The ego has flared. I am trying to prove the clay pot has no cracks in it.

When a peer pushes back, they are tapping on the pot. The ego wants to defend it. Stepping away, feeling the tightness, and letting the ego die a little death is the only way the work stays front and centre.

We are not the source. We are the crockery.

Lord, we have wanted the gold.
We have wanted the measurable fix,
and we have called that serving you.
Teach us the clay.
You have never needed our strategies.
You have only ever needed our presence.

AMEN

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1 I worked through Balthasar's theological aesthetics at more length in a podcast episode: Balthasar's Theology of Beauty (audio).

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.